

Nation **POLL**DIARY

BETTER ByHaves



SPRAOAS

PAPPU WITH
WIFE RANJITA

In 1997, when Lalu Prasad, hemmed in by a CBI warrant, installed his wife Rabri Devi as the chief minister of Bihar, he set a precedent for Biharis bahubalis to follow in 2009.

Today, on the eve of the Lok Sabha elections, at least two convicted members of Parliament from Bihar who have become ineligible to contest polls have made their parties field their wives in their place. Heena Shahab is the RD candidate from Siwan because her husband Mohd Shahabuddin, the incumbent MP is debarred. The Lok Janshakti Party fielded Veena Singh from Nawada after its sitting MP Surabhan was convicted of murder. Pappu Yadav's wife Ranjita Ranjan is a sitting MP but he has the carte blanche to nominate a successor from Madhepura. Lalu was truly ahead of his time.

by Amitabh Srivastava

Star Struck

Actor and Trinamool Congress candidate from Birbhum Lok Sabha seat Shatabdi Roy has tough competition ahead. And it's not a candidate, but a calendar of actor Katrina Kaif that is giving her sleepless nights. The calendar, which is quite a rage, has Kaif's picture with Indian National Congress written at the bottom. With Kaif playing a politician's role inspired by Congress President Sonia Gandhi in *Rajneeti*, this may just be a coincidence, but can spoil the Congress-Trinamool friendship.

by Abhijeet Dasgupta



SHATABDI ROY

SYNOPSIS/ILLUSTRATION

Missing A BEAT

The hearts of many Third Front leaders skipped their beats after BSP chief Mayawati arrived in Hyderabad last week and left without meeting TDP chief N. Chandrababu Naidu.

DIPLOMATIC CIRCLING

Heads of diplomatic missions in New Delhi are these days seen less in South Block and more in the offices of key political parties courting leaders to see that their countries stay on top of the new government's agenda.

Battle of THE CHIEFS

All of them have been chief ministers; most of them have been both to the Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha and one has even been the prime minister, albeit for a brief period. But the itch to be in their trade in the big arena persists. So Karnataka will see a first of sorts as six former chief ministers sweat it out in the coming days to enter the Lok Sabha. They are S. Bangarappa, M. Veerappa Moily, S.M. Krishna, N. Dharam Singh, H.D. Deve Gowda, and his son H.D. Kumaraswamy. Since B.S. Yeddyurappa is busy minding the state, he has sent his son Vijender to keep the seat warm.



GOOWDA

by Stephen David



SPRAOAS

Facts of the Matter

During the last Lok Sabha polls, of the 543 seats, 219 seats were won by candidates who secured 50 per cent or more of the total votes polled in their respective constituencies. While in Tamil Nadu, the winning candidates secured over 50 per cent of the total votes polled in 34 of the 39 seats, in Uttar Pradesh only nine out of 80 seats were won by this margin.